of security will change according to its capabilities vis-à-vis other countries and the international constraints it faces.[4] In search of security, it is important to find the balance between power politics and economic growth (warfare versus welfare or power versus wealth), and if a state's power is insufficient to gain security, it might be forced to seek alignment with other countries.

India is, together with Russia (and formerly the Soviet Union), the most powerful country sharing a land border with China and potentially the most powerful neighbour. Accordingly, Beijing's policy on India has been to balance three goals: to hem in Indian power; to prevent it from dominating South Asia; and to ensure that it does not drift too close into an alignment with other great powers, meaning the Soviet Union during the Cold War and more recently the United States.

China's approach on India to attain these goals has at any given time been influenced by four main variables: first, the situation on the border and the potential threat India represents to stability on China's volatile western frontier. Second, as China has never been inferior to India, its stance on India has reflected the larger picture with regard to the balance of power in the international system, and this has changed dramatically on several occasions since 1949. Third, is China's evolving geostrategy, understood as the geographic thrust and direction of a state's foreign policy. India's central or peripheral position therein informs the role of India in China's foreign policy. Finally, Beijing's shifting priorities towards power politics versus wealth and economic growth in pursuing its grand strategy have consequences for its approach on India.

Depending on the larger context of China's grand strategy and the four variables specified previously, China has, throughout the period from 1949, pursued various balancing strategies towards India but at times also attempted to engage it. In this chapter, I will explore how this has played